



# Black Orlov diamond

△ **Nadezhda Petrovna Orlov**, one of the diamond's former owners

The Black Orlov diamond, also known as the Eye of Brahma, is famous for its distinctive colour and notorious for its curse, which is said to bring doom to its owners.

The Black Orlov's colour is not true black but a gunmetal dark grey. The original rough 195-carat stone was later cut to a 67.50-carat cushion cut. It is currently set in a pendant, surrounded by a leaf motif of 800 smaller white diamonds, and hangs from a platinum necklace set with 124 small white diamonds.

The diamond's history is uncertain. It is said to have originally been an eye in a statue of the god Brahma in India, but became cursed after it was stolen by a travelling monk. Supposedly, American diamond buyer JW Paris purchased the stone in 1932, sold it, and jumped to his death from a New York skyscraper shortly afterwards. Later, according to the story of the curse, Russian princess Leonilla



**The Black Orlov diamond**  
set with hundreds of  
white diamonds

Bariatinskaia fell to her death in Rome in 1947 after acquiring the stone – and one month after that, the stone's new owner, Princess Nadia Vyegin-Orlov, also fell to her death from a building in Rome.

As with many “cursed” jewels, the truth is debatable. The story of its origin is suspiciously similar to that of the Orlov diamond, a white diamond stolen from an Indian idol and owned by the Orlovs. Mr Paris's plunge went unrecorded, and “Princess Nadia Vyegin-Orlov” is not known as a historical figure. Of the real princesses who owned the stone, Princess Leonilla died in 1918, aged 101, and Nadezhda Petrovna Orlov, who gave the diamond its name, died in 1988, aged about 90. The curse may be baseless, but it has done much for the Black Orlov's mystique.



**The Hindu god Brahma**, who is said to have placed a terrible curse on the Eye of Brahma jewel after a travelling monk stole it from a statue of the deity

## I'm pretty confident that the curse is broken...

J Dennis **Petimezas**  
Owner, 2004–06

## Key dates

### Pre-1800s–2006

**Unknown** The diamond is supposedly stolen from the eye of Brahma in a shrine in Pondicherry, India, by a monk and is cursed

1800



**Hindu pagoda in Pondicherry, c.1867**

**Early 1900s** The Black Orlov's necklace reaches Russia and passes through the hands of “Princess Nadia Vyegin-Orlov” and Princess Leonilla Bariatinskaia

1900

1910

**1918** Princess Leonilla Bariatinskaia actually dies in France aged 101

**1932** JW Paris buys the diamond, sells it, and, shortly after, jumps from skyscraper in New York

1920

**1947** “Princess Vyegin-Orlov” and Princess Leonilla Bariatinskaia allegedly leap to their deaths in Rome, just one month apart

1950

**c.1950s** Charles F. Winson, a New York City gem dealer, buys the stone from persons unrecorded. It is later set in a pendant

**1988** The real Princess Nadezhda Petrovna Orlov, on whom Princess Nadia may be based, dies aged around 90 in Switzerland

1980

**1995** The diamond is auctioned to an anonymous collector for \$1.5 million

1990

**2004** J. Dennis Petimezas, a jeweller and diamond dealer, acquires the diamond from anonymous private collector

2000

**2006** The Natural History Museum's “Diamonds Exhibition” in London featuring the diamond is closed early due to threat of robbery